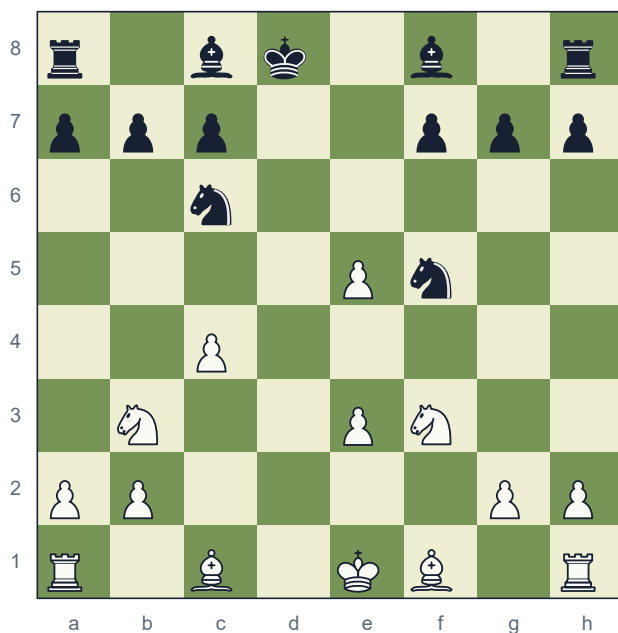


Albin Countergambit: a complete practical answer

1.d4 d5 2.c4 e5 3.dxe5 d4 4.Nf3 Nc6 5.Nbd2

YOUR REPERTOIRE CHOICE

Accept the e5 pawn, develop Nf3, and use Nbd2 with the idea Nb3 against d4. You are not obliged to keep every extra pawn: king safety and neutralizing d4 come first.



Main-line anchor - Black to move

THE PAWN STRUCTURE

White has an extra pawn on e5; Black has a space-gaining wedge on d4. The d-file, the diagonal to e1, and the f3 knight are the tactical features to track.

WHAT BLACK WANTS

Black wants ...Bg4 or ...Be6, quick development, and sometimes queenside castling. The wedge can advance or capture on e3; it must never disappear from your threat scan.

THREE HABITS TO BUILD

1. 5.Nbd2 is a repertoire choice, not a forced refutation of the Albin.
2. Do not play 4.e3 on autopilot: ...Bb4+ and ...dxe3 create the Lasker trap.
3. The plan Nb3 targets d4, but first account for pins and queen pressure against e5.
4. After Black castles long, queenside pawn play can become an attack rather than a slow positional plan.

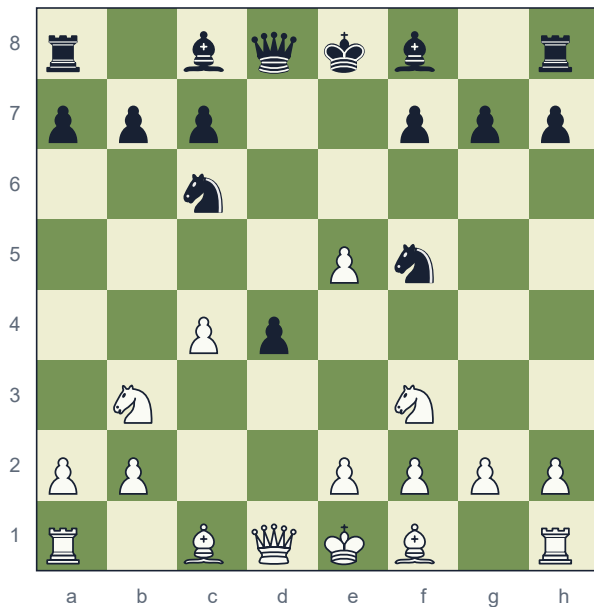
Line pages contain a selected opening anchor plus an illustrative checked continuation. They are not a forced script. Sources and method: Booklet 26.

01 Main choice: ...Nge7 and the queen trade

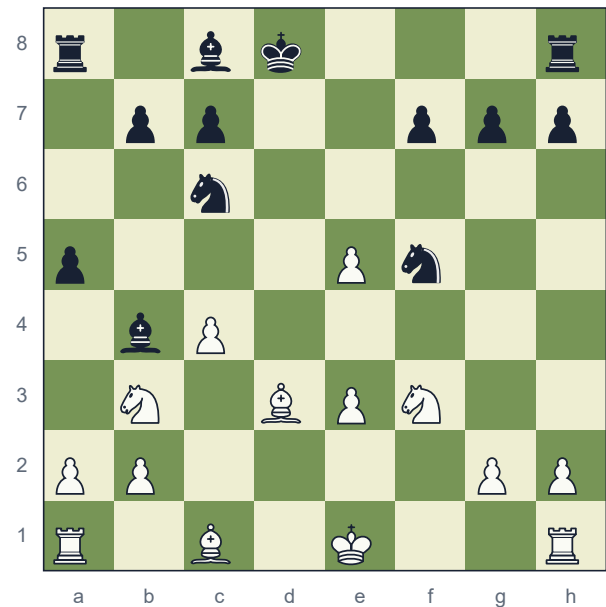
STUDY LINE 08-01

1. d4 d5 2. c4 e5 3. dxe5 d4 4. Nf3 Nc6 5. Nbd2 Nge7 6. Nb3 Nf5 7. e4 dxe3 8. Qxd8+ Kxd8 9. fxe3 a5 10. Bd3 Bb4+

Selected anchor ends with 9. fxe3. Later moves illustrate one checked continuation.



Checkpoint after move 6 - White to move



End of study line - White to move - in check

WHY THESE MOVES

Nbd2-b3 attacks d4. e4 challenges the knight and allows an en-passant capture; Qxd8+ first is essential to understand the resulting queenless position.

YOUR NEXT PLAN

First answer the check shown in the final diagram. Develop the bishops, bring the king to a safe useful square, and use the extra material without rushing. Your e-pawns are doubled, so assess activity as well as pawn count.

WATCH FOR

After e2-e4, ...dxe3 is en passant. Do not draw the pawn on e4 as if it survived that capture.

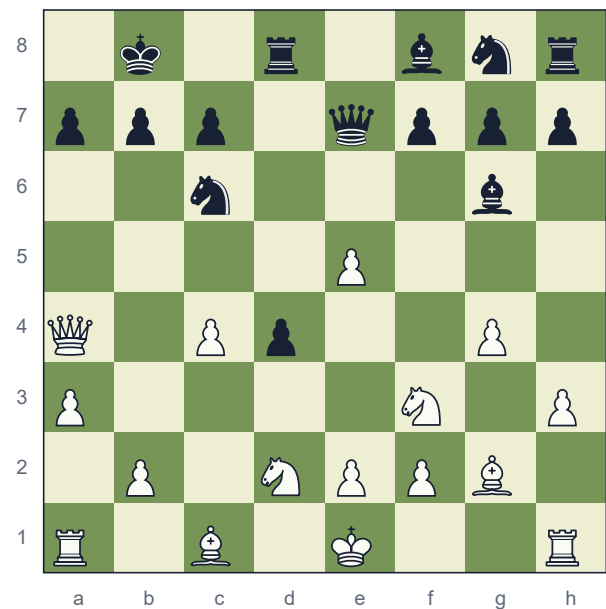
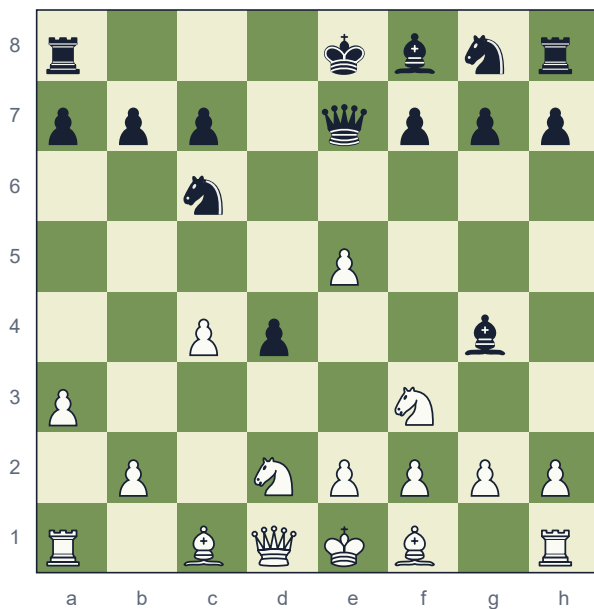
REMEMBER Nb3, e4, and understand the queen trade.

02 The pin: ...Bg4 and ...Qe7

STUDY LINE 08-02

1. d4 d5 2. c4 e5 3. dxe5 d4 4. Nf3 Nc6 5. Nbd2 Bg4 6. a3 Qe7 7. h3 Bh5 8. Qa4 O-O-O 9. g4 Bg6 10. Bg2 Kb8

Selected anchor ends with 8. Qa4. Later moves illustrate one checked continuation.



WHY THESE MOVES

a3 prevents ...Bb4+; h3 asks the bishop to choose. Qa4 creates queenside pressure while Black spends time placing the queen on e7.

YOUR NEXT PLAN

Meet castling long with useful queenside development and possibly b4. If Black regains e5, exchange accurately and complete development.

WATCH FOR

The f3 knight is pinned to the queen while the bishop stays on g4 or h5. Capturing with it can expose a queen capture.

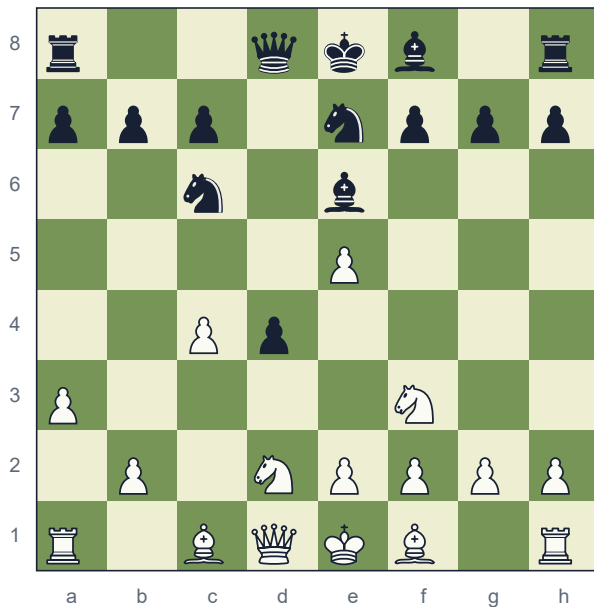
REMEMBER Deal with the pin before collecting another pawn.

03 ...Be6 and the d4 blockade

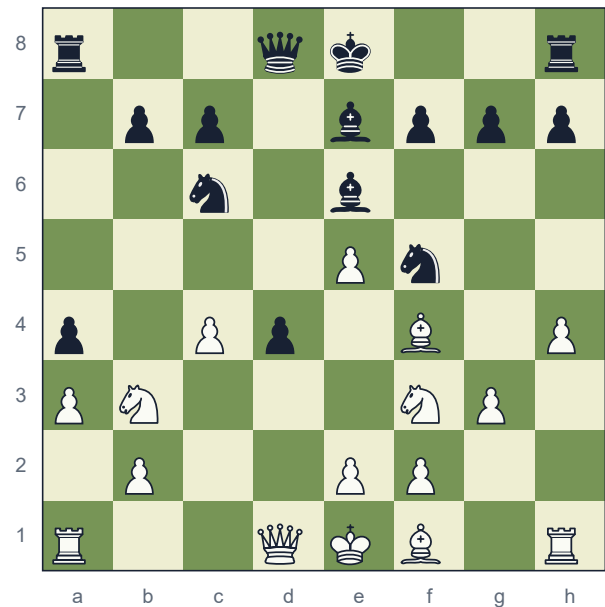
STUDY LINE 08-03

1. d4 d5 2. c4 e5 3. dxe5 d4 4. Nf3 Nc6 5. Nbd2 Be6 6. a3 Nge7 7. Nb3 Nf5 8. g3 Be7 9. h4 a5 10. Bf4 a4

Selected anchor ends with 8. g3. Later moves illustrate one checked continuation.



Checkpoint after move 6 - White to move



End of study line - White to move

WHY THESE MOVES

The bishop on e6 supports active development. The fianchetto provides a safe king scheme while the b3 knight questions d4.

YOUR NEXT PLAN

Bg2 and castling are sensible aims. Check whether an exchange on d4 opens lines against your king or improves your center.

WATCH FOR

Do not grab d4 if Black can exploit a pin, a check, or the loose e5 pawn with tempo.

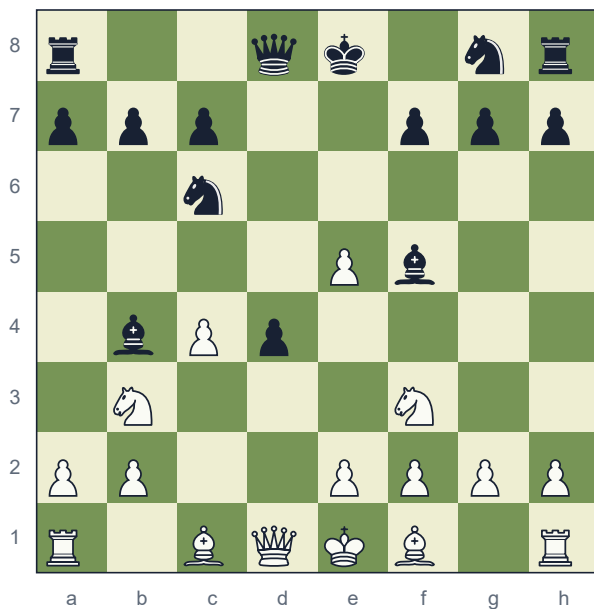
REMEMBER Attack the wedge while building king safety.

04 ...Bf5 allows Nb3 with tempo ideas

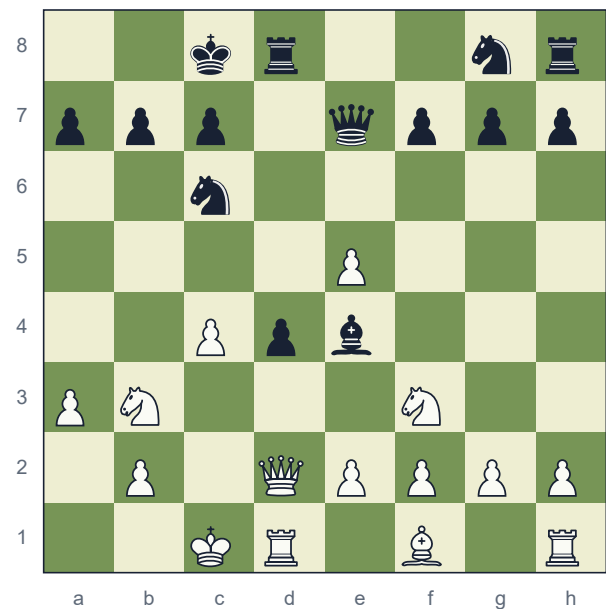
STUDY LINE 08-04

1. d4 d5 2. c4 e5 3. dxe5 d4 4. Nf3 Nc6 5. Nbd2 Bf5 6. Nb3 Bb4+ 7. Bd2 Qe7 8. a3 Bxd2+ 9. Qxd2 Be4 10. O-O-O O-O-O

Selected anchor ends with 9. Qxd2. Later moves illustrate one checked continuation.



Checkpoint after move 6 - White to move - in check



End of study line - White to move

WHY THESE MOVES

Nb3 prepares a capture on d4 that would hit Bf5. Meet the check by developing Bd2 and recapture on d2 with the queen.

YOUR NEXT PLAN

Finish development; do not assume that castling on either side is automatically safe. The queen on d2 helps you organize the position.

WATCH FOR

A line with the bishop on f5 is not identical to the ...Bg4 pin. Tactical defenses differ.

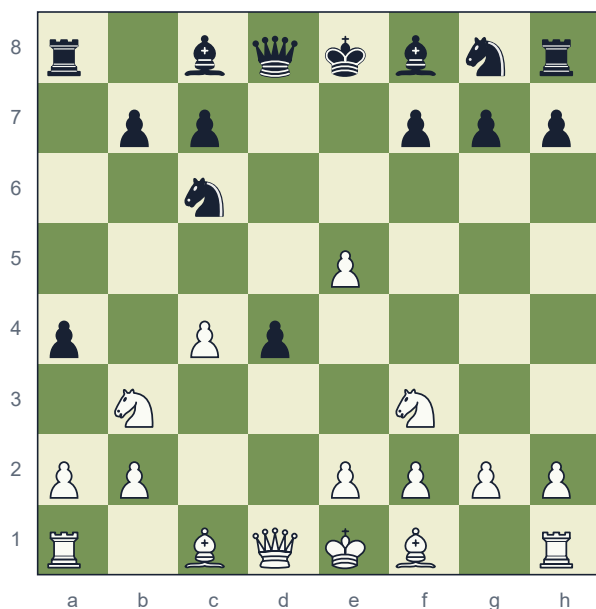
REMEMBER Use the exposed bishop to gain time on d4.

05 An early ...a5 restrains b4

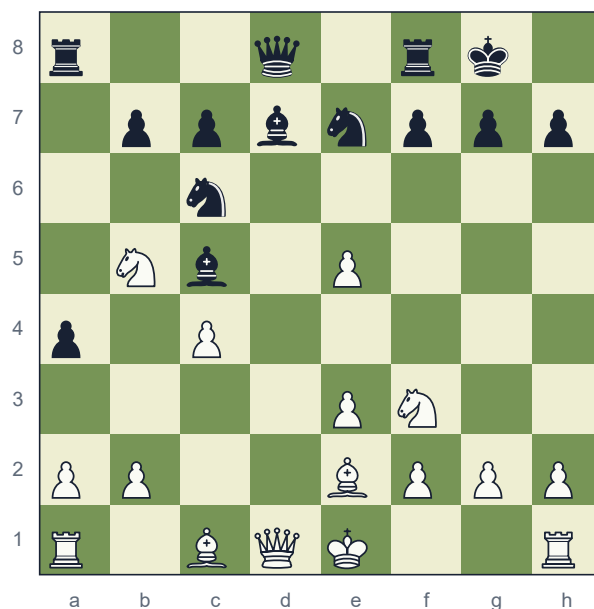
STUDY LINE 08-05

1. d4 d5 2. c4 e5 3. dxe5 d4 4. Nf3 Nc6 5. Nbd2 a5 6. Nb3 a4 7. Nbx d4 Bc5 8. e3 Nge7 9. Be2 O-O 10. Nb5 Bd7

Selected anchor ends with 7. Nbx d4. Later moves illustrate one checked continuation.



Checkpoint after move 6 - White to move



End of study line - White to move

WHY THESE MOVES

The knight takes the central wedge instead of retreating passively from the a-pawn. The point of Nb3 was to make d4 a target.

YOUR NEXT PLAN

Develop the remaining pieces and castle if safe. Black has spent time on the a-pawn and may seek compensation through open lines.

WATCH FOR

Check which knight can capture d4; write Nbx d4 when both knights could reach that square.

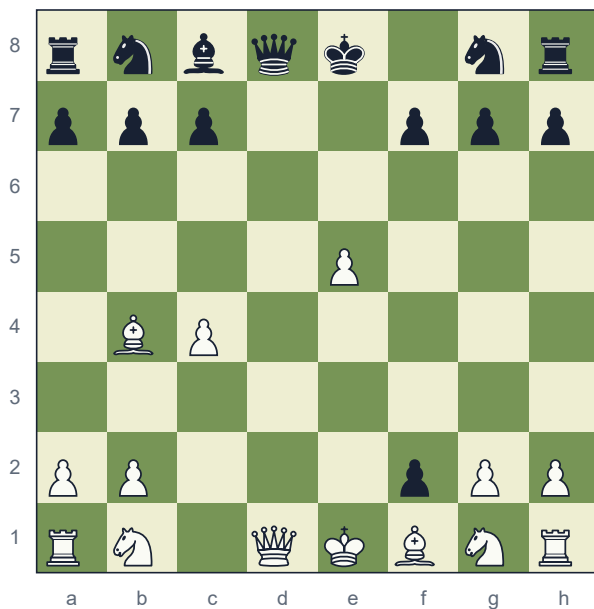
REMEMBER Answer flank threats with a concrete central resource.

06 Warning only: the Lasker underpromotion trap

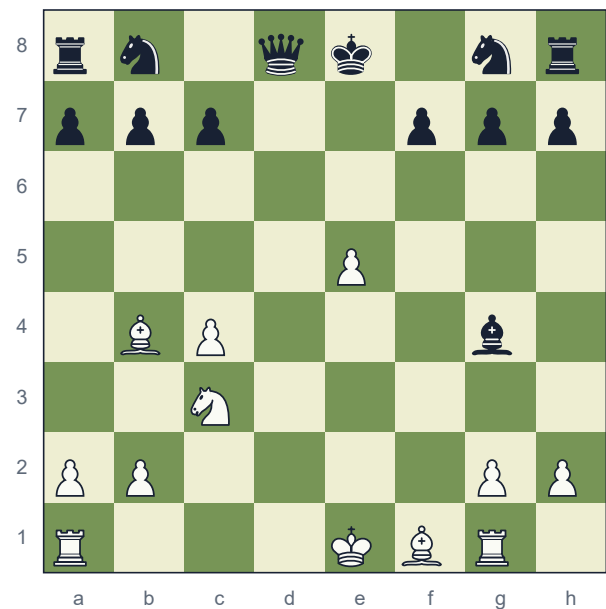
WARNING EXAMPLE - DO NOT PLAY THIS AS WHITE

1. d4 d5 2. c4 e5 3. dxe5 d4 4. e3 Bb4+ 5. Bd2 dxe3 6. Bxb4 exf2+ 7. Ke2 fxg1=N+ 8. Rxb1 Bg4+ 9. Ke1 Bxd1 10. Nc3 Bg4

Selected anchor ends with 9... Bxd1. Later moves illustrate one checked continuation.



Checkpoint after move 6 - White to move - in check



End of study line - White to move

WHY THESE MOVES

This is a demonstration of what not to play. 4.e3 allows ...Bb4+; 6.Bxb4 ignores the passed pawn, and promotion to a knight comes with check.

YOUR NEXT PLAN

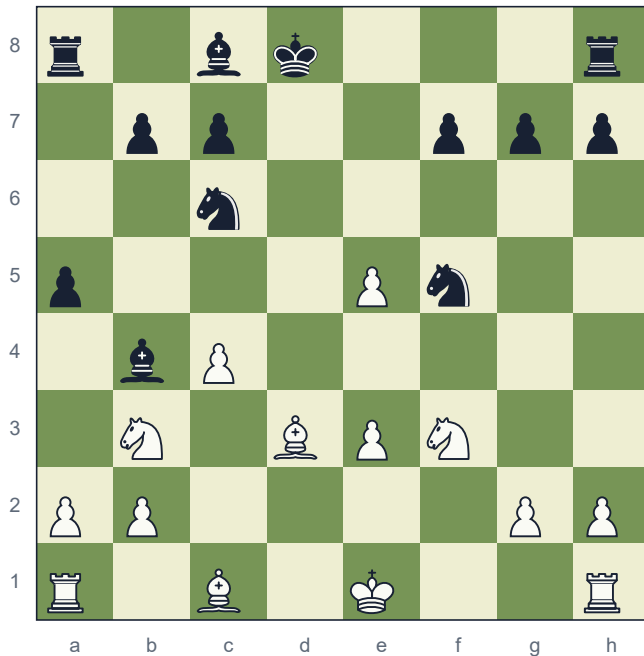
Avoid this entire mess with the recommended 4.Nf3. If you have already played e3, stop before capturing the bishop and examine checks and passed-pawn threats.

WATCH FOR

After ...fxg1=N+, the promoted knight attacks e2. Promotion to a queen would not create that same knight check.

REMEMBER Checks and promotion threats outrank a free-looking bishop.

Review before your next game



Main-line study position - White to move - in check

1. IDENTIFY THE STRUCTURE.

White has an extra pawn on e5; Black has a space-gaining wedge on d4. The d-file, the diagonal to e1, and the f3 knight are the tactical features to track.

2. NAME BLACK'S PLAN.

Black wants ...Bg4 or ...Be6, quick development, and sometimes queenside castling. The wedge can advance or capture on e3; it must never disappear from your threat scan.

3. CHOOSE YOUR NEXT JOB.

Develop the bishops, bring the king to a safe useful square, and use the extra material without rushing. Your e-pawns are doubled, so assess activity as well as pawn count.

RECONSTRUCTION DRILL

Set up the starting position and play the main study line without looking. After each Black move, say what changed. If you cannot explain your reply, stop at that position and review the relevant line page.

DECISION DRILL

Return to the diagram. Write two candidate moves and a likely reply to each. You are not trying to guess the next engine move: you are testing whether your choices fit the structure and survive checks, captures and threats.

SELF-CHECK

Can you identify every capture and recapture in the line? Can you state one move-order exception? Can you explain the final position without using the opening name?

Related practice: Booklet 24. Use the matching line ID in the PGN companion. Opening names: Lichess public opening dataset; original course choices and analysis, checked with Stockfish 18.